
INTRODUCTION TO BUSINESS MESSAGE WRITING

HS (208/304)

BUSINESS COMMUNICATION AND ETHICS

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BUSINESS MESSAGES

- Business Messages solve communication Problems, which is possible only because they meet the needs of the writer and the writer's organization, be sensitive to the audience and accurately reflect the topic being written about.
- In short, if they have audience centered approach and they build sender's goodwill, only then it is possible.

PLANNING STEPS

1. Knowing the purpose of the message.
2. Visualizing the reader (receiver).
3. Choosing the ideas to be included.
4. Getting all the facts to back up the ideas.
5. Outlining and organizing the message.

I. KNOWING THE PURPOSE OF THE MESSAGE:

- Purpose is the primary reason to write or speak. Its identification leads to determination of the contents of the message.
- Each message must have a specific purpose e.g. asking for rebate on defective goods, announcing clearance sale, awakening inactive amount, making inquiry, seeking job etc. in addition to the specific purpose, the general purpose of every business message must be to establish good will and good relations.
- For example, the purpose of a collection letter should be two-fold i.e. asking for money and at the same time maintaining good relations with the customer.

2.VISUALIZING THE READER:

It is very important to adapt the message to the reader's views. But writer often does not know much about the reader. However, attempt should be made to know about the following points.

- a. What relationship is with the reader? Is the reader a customer or a supplier, a boss or a subordinate?
- b. What is position of the reader? Is reader an engineer or an accountant, a supervisor or an executive?
- c. What is reading level of the reader? It can be guessed by noting the educational qualification, technical training, professional status and experience of the reader.
- d. What are interests of the reader relating to job and social activities?
- e. How much reader knows about the subject matter and its background?
- f. Is the reader prejudiced or biased on religious, political and social issues?
- g. What are reader's unspoken needs for information? This can be known by reading between the lines.

3.CHOOSING THE IDEAS:

- The next step is to choose the ideas. The ideas to include depend upon the message being communicated. For example. A welcome letter to a customer, should include the following ideas:
 - a. Welcoming and thanking the reader for opening the account.
 - b. Stating the services and facilities offered to regular customers.
 - c. Mentioning the working hours.
 - d. Informing about the credit terms and discount rates.
 - e. Assuring to help in solving the customer's problems.

4. GETTING ALL THE FACTS:

- The facts and figures to be stated in a message may be certain names, dates, address, percentages, statements etc. for some messages all the facts may be in the writer's mind, but for others extensive primary and / or secondary research may be needed for collecting the required data.

Primary Research:

Primary research data may be collected by any of the following research methods.

- Experimental Research Method:** Which seeks to determine whether a change in one factor causes change in another.
- Observational Research Method:** Which involves either human or mechanical viewing of the actions or results of some-hearing, touching, smelling etc.
- Survey Research Method:** Which requires the researcher collect data from respondents through questionnaires.
- Combination of the Various Research Method:** May also be used when any one of the above methods is not appropriate.

4. GETTING ALL THE FACTS:

Secondary Research:

Secondary research data may be collected from the following sources.

- a. Company Publications: Newsletters, bulletins, brochures, pamphlets, handbooks, manuals and company records and reports.
- b. Books: Relating to the topic under research.
- c. Periodicals: Magazines, journals and newspapers published at regular intervals.
- d. Other Sources: Radio and T.V. programmes, publications of other companies and professional association.

5. OUTLINING AND ORGANIZING THE MESSAGE:

- Before writing a message, it should be outlined and organized either on paper or mentally. There are four different organizational plans – the direct request, good news, bad news and persuasive request. The first two use the direct approach and the last two, the indirect approach.

6. REVISING AND EDITING AND PROOF READING:

- The draft should be read paragraph by paragraph, sentence by sentence and word by word to check the continuity of ideas and grammatical, punctuation and spelling mistakes. While revising and editing the message it must be ensured that the message meets all the principles of good business communication.
- A careful proof reading is essential after the revised and edited message has been finally typewritten. Before it is mailed, it should be read by responsible and reliable person, because errors, if left un-corrected, may result in loss of goodwill, sales, income and even lives.

THREE TYPES OF BUSINESS MESSAGES (BASED ON PURPOSE AND RESPONSE)

1. Routine/Neutral/Informative/Good news/Positive/Goodwill Messages
2. Bad News/Negative Messages
3. Persuasive Messages

EXAMPLES OF 3 TYPES OF BUSINESS MESSAGES

Routine/positive Messages	Bad News Messages	Persuasive Messages
Inquiries and information about procedures, products/services, options.	Rejection and refusal to requests	Orders, requests, proposals, recommendations
Announcements of policy/policy changes	Regrets	Sales, fund-raising letters
Acceptances	Announcements of policies/ policy changes which have disadvantage to the reader	Job Applications
Positive answers to reader's requests	Negative performance appraisals	Efforts to change people's behaviour e.g. collection letters, criticism or performance appraisals
Introduction to staff and employees regarding systems/procedures	Disciplinary notices, notices of defects	Public service messages/ads e.g. drugs, safe driving

PURPOSES OF 3 TYPES OF BUSINESS MESSAGES

Routine/positive Messages	Bad News Messages	Persuasive Messages
Primary Purposes	Convey the bad news	Primary Purposes
To give information or good news to the reader or to reassure the reader	Gain acceptance for it	To have the reader act
To have the reader read the message, understand it and view the information positively	Maintain as much goodwill as possible with the audience	To provide enough information so that the reader knows exactly what to do
To deemphasize any negative element		To overcome any objections that might prevent or delay actions
Secondary Purposes • To build a good image of the writer • To build a good image of the writer's organization • To cement a good relationship between the writer and the reader • To reduce or eliminate future correspondence on the same subject so the message does not create more work to the writer.		

ORGANIZATIONAL PLAN FOR 3 TYPES OF BUSINESS MESSAGES

Routine/positive Messages	Bad News Messages	Persuasive Messages
1. State the request or main idea	1. Buffer	1. Gain attention
2. Give necessary details	2. Explanation	2. Create Interest
3. Close with a cordial request for specific action	3. Bad News	3. Build Desire
	4. Courteous Close	4. Enforce Action
Direct Organizational Plan	Indirect Organizational Plan	AIDA Approach